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Borough Township-Vanport--A Brief History

Vanport's history really stems from the following Indian tribes: Allegewi, Massawarna, Shawanese and the Delewares. They camped along the river banks and at the base of the hills.

The hill, now known as "Bear Hill," was the "look-out point" where they had an advantage to watch all proceedings of the soldiers at Fort McIntosh.

Relics and artifacts have been found to corroborate the presence of their burial grounds where, now, the new highway extends.

According to available records, an Indian by the name of Amockwi, later known as "the Beaver," or "King Beaver," was the main speaker between the whites and the Indians. He attended many peace parleys trying to formulate a permanent promise between the two over the land dispute. He stated he was not so interested in the land division, as he was interested in both sides living in peace. He was buried where the Tuscarawas Trail crossed Two Mile Run.

According to these facts he can be credited as our first local peacemaker and politician.

Borough Township was formed in November, 1804, with a population of the territory approximately 376. The boundaries being the Ohio River on the South, Brighton Township on the North and West and Beaver Borough on the Northeast. This finding the Borough a central part of the county.

In 1835, Thomas B. Boggs laid out the town of Vanport, located on the north bank of the Ohio River, about two miles below Beaver. J. J. Noss built the first brick house. The land was found hilly and rough and laden with lime which became the principle product of the Borough. The name Vanport originated from two sources. First, the democratic nominee for

president at the time was Martin Van Buren. During a political demonstration, members of the party decided as a compliment to the leader, "Matty Van" they would name the town after him. The "port" was natural because much pottery was shipped from Vanport.

Due to the location of the four potteries, owned by A. Russell, Enoch Powers and Amos Douth, a ferry was built where the Two Mile Creek empties into the Ohio River. Two lime kilns were located west of the ferry. Other potteries were owned by John Weaver, Mudlick Hollow, 1840-1860 and "Doc" Fowler's on State Avenue.

The first locomotive crossed the Ohio River Railroad Bridge September 21,

1878. This bridge was 2550 feet long and 90 feet above the water. During the 1884 flood this bridge was knocked out.

The Methodists dedicated their first church, known as the Dravo Chapel, November 21, 1869. Reverend Sylvester Burt delivered the first sermon. The trustees were Enoch Fowler, George Dobbs, John Moore, Amos Russell, Lucius Conrad, Samuel Johnston and Amos Douth.

John Weaver made the arrangements for the dedication of the first Baptist Church, February 24, 1861. Others who assisted were James Porter and Hiram Noss. Reverend Dinsmore was the first pastor, being succeeded by Reverend Davis. The church failed.

John McKinzie, William McKinzie, Est White, Clark Rogers, Joshua Larkin and David Engle, tried to establish a United Brethren Church later, but this also failed.

The Presbyterian Church was organized January 1890. Darius Singleton and John M. Buchanan purchased the old Baptist Church building for their chapel. In the beginning ninety-one members attended, this total growing to 285 communicant members. The first minister was Reverend A. Krichbaum. In 1964 the congregation was informed by the Pennsylvania Highway Department that a highway would take their property. Through

the fortitude of the members, in the fall of 1965 a new church was built on Georgetown Lane. Reverend W. H. Bell being the minister. Reverend R. J. Anderson now officiating after Reverend George Espy left in 1972.



Vanport Presbyterian Church

The Ladies Aid Society of the church was organized March 23, 1893. Reverend Krichbaum framed their charter. They are still at work for the good of their church.

Homesteads and farms flourished. J. J. Noss' large white and brick home was built in or about 1846. But an earlier estate which became known as Mulvanen's Foley was erected in 1840. It seems Patrick Mulvanen built this home for his fiancée, Miss Anna Mines. It was a stately mansion, with large white pillars, which gave it the name of the "white house" by residents of Vanport. The rooms were immense with beautiful carved fireplaces in each room. The entire east end of the house was one big room called the ball room. A huge stairway led to the third floor which had two large bedrooms and smaller rooms for storage. There was also a carriage house built several hundred feet to the west of the house. For some unknown reason the marriage to Miss Mines never occurred and Patrick's dreams were shattered. The "white house" then became known as "Mulvanen's Foley." In 1850, Captain and Mrs. Thomas Greenlee bought the home and raised their family of six girls and two boys. The youngest daughter, Stella Greenlee married J. P. Ross and retained their residence there with their daughter, Evelyn. During an electrical storm, lightning

struck and caused a fire, but it did not destroy the house. Years later it was sold to Mr. and Mrs. Hugh Nieman, who remodeled it. They eventually moved and rented it to Mr and Mrs. C. C. Townsend who lived there only a short time. Then Mr. and Mrs. Sweet occupied the premises and rented apartments. After a few years it changed hands again and a tea-room was started but not successful. The home was then sold to Mr. and Mrs. Henry Foster, antique dealers, who finally sold it to the last owner, Mr. and Mrs. Charles Brown. With this, the dreams and laughter, tears and hopes to retain it as an historical site went down, as the Beaver Valley Expressway bought the right of way through its property. The mansion was to remain in the memories of the older citizens forever. (Historical data submitted by Mrs. Paul Mortimer, Mrs. Ross Todd and Mrs. Anna Brown).

M. C. Harton built his home at the corner of North Walnut and Division Lane in 1904. He was a contractor for building and stone work for bridges, like the Fombell Bridge in 1901 and the Bradys Run Bridge and also helped to build the barns at Old Economy. He was a civil war veteran. He guarded the people implicated in the assassination of President Lincoln, while they were in prison, until they were executed. He was the father of two children, Walter and Margret. He died in 1919, at the age of 79.

Michael Baker, Sr., a surveyor, and his family owned property off Division Lane. Mrs. Baker died in 1912, leaving a family of eight children. Michael Baker, Jr. was only seven weeks old. The Baker family moved to Beaver in 1914.

The first post office was in the home of Wade Drear, Jefferson Street. Mrs. Hill was the first postmistress, 1882. Harry Drear came to Vanport at the age of four. He opened a barber shop in 1898. He retired in 1956 as the last charter member of the hairdressers and barbers union local 280. He also had the only piano and organ business in town, was a justice of the peace and a Borough Township commissioner. He died at the age of 85.



Post Office 1932. Jesse Jones, postmistress

The first school house in Vanport was a one room school located at the corner of Washington and Jefferson Streets. Today it is the home of Wade Drear.

The second school was two rooms located at the corner of Georgetown Lane and Ferry Street. The third school, being used today, is located at the corner of Jefferson and Dravo streets. The building, started in 1913, was completed in 1914 in time for the school term.

The first grocery store was owned by Miller Flocker on Washington Street, then he moved to State Avenue. C. C. Denny opened his store in 1901 on State Avenue and Washington Street. He retired in 1945. George Gunta was the last grocer in the Flocker building. In 1898 to 1901 J. T. Anderson, Sr. had a grocery on State Avenue. Then he moved to Beaver. Other stores were Ammon's butcher shop and Loncher's on Ferry Street.

The first dentist in town was Jim Shumaker, an uncle of Mrs. Florence Hays, Vanport. Belle McCullough was his first patient and got her teeth at half price. His office was on State Avenue.

The first gas station was owned by Wes Gordon, who sold it to Pugh and White for a Sunoco Station. Gordon sold it after being in business for 15 to 20 years, in 1934.

(Recorded from the township records of minutes)

Board of Road Commissioners of Borough Township met at the school house Monday, March 7, 1904, 7:30 p.m.

Sworn in by Justice of the Peace M. Flocker (also tax assessor) are: President, J. H. Waggoner; Vice president, Issac Minor; Clerk, Jos. A. Bradley; Road Supervisor, Wm. C. Fisher and Township Solicitor, D. A. Nelson.

Mr. Smith of the Beaver Star attended March 8, 1904.

On motion by J. McTaggart, seconded by Albert Conrad, the wages for the laborers were fixed at one dollar and fifty cents and teams (of horses) at four dollars and fifty cents per day of nine hours.

"In reply to a question by Hayes in regard to his fee, as council, Mr. Nelson stated his fee would be "\$50.00 per year for all required by the board except in case of law suits."

According to minutes dated May 24, 1900, meeting held at the home of James C. Witherow, with all supervisors, including John Sebring and clerk, Emmet J. Hall, the electric railway was introduced and voted approval.

quote, "On motion by Witherow, seconded by Sebring, the following resolution was adopted. That the Ohio Valley Electric Street Railway Company, its successors and assigns, shall have the right, and is hereby authorized to enter upon the following road or highway within the said township of Borough.

Beginning at a point on the road commonly called the River Road where the said road crosses the tracks of the Cleveland and Pittsburg Railroad, thence westwardly along said River Road to the western boundary of said Borough Township: and there to construct, maintain and operate thereon such motors, electric or other appliances, necessary turnouts and switches, and mechanical fixtures by means of an overhead system or otherwise, as the said Ohio Valley Electric Street Railway Company, its successors and assigns, may at' anytime select for the traction or operation of cars upon and along said road or highway, at any part or parts thereof. etc."

Vanport became a first class township in 1890.

